QUICK GUIDE

GAIN STAGING

What it is, how to spot it and what to do with it.

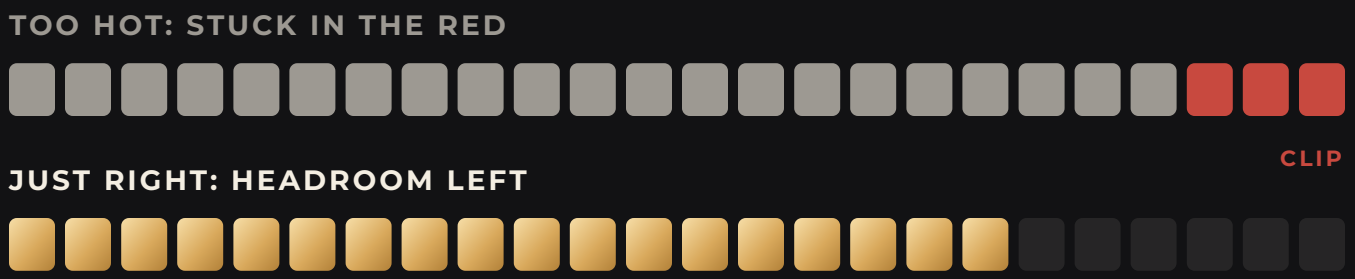
WHAT IT IS

Gain staging means setting each level in the chain so nothing is too hot. Trim sets the starting level of each track, the faders do the mixing, and the master stays below clipping.

WHAT YOU'LL NOTICE

Clean and punchy. The mix has room to breathe instead of sounding harsh.

TOO HOT VS JUST RIGHT



01

TRIM FROM THE LOUDEST PART

Set gain on the drop or chorus, not the quiet intro.

02

TRIM, NOT FADERS

Fix level gaps with trim. Keep faders for mixing.

03

CUT, DON'T BOOST

Cut the bass on the incoming track instead of stacking two lows.

DO THIS TONIGHT

Re-trim ten tracks on their loudest part and keep the master out of the red.

- [ ] Cue the track and jump to its loudest section.
- [ ] Set trim so the channel peaks just below the red.
- [ ] Record one blend and check the master never clips.



PRACTICE & CHECK

GAIN STAGING: YOUR TURN

WHERE YOU'LL MEET IT AS A DJ

- Matching the level of tracks that were mastered differently.
- Making room for the incoming bass instead of stacking it.
- Keeping the output clean on a loud system.

QUICK CHECK

1. Where do you set trim?

2. How do you fix a level gap?

3. How do you make room for new bass?

Answer key: 1) On the loudest section of the track. 2) With trim, not the fader. 3) Cut the old bass. Don't boost the new.

REMEMBER

Clean levels first. Then loud.

YOUR NOTES

UP NEXT One Effect, One Job

